

A Few Words About Validation

What is it exactly?

Simply put, it tells someone "your feelings make sense. Not only do I hear you, but I understand why you feel the way you do. You are not bad or wrong or crazy for feeling the way you do."

It means:

- Finding the kernel of truth in another person's perspective or situation
- Acknowledging that a person's emotions, thoughts, and behaviours have causes and are therefore understandable
- Not necessarily agreeing with the other person
- Not validating what is actually invalid
- Not saying we like it

Why Validate?

- It improves our relationships by showing we are listening and understand
- It reduces:
 - Pressure to prove who is right
 - Negative reactivity
 - Fueling anger
- It makes problem solving, closeness, and support possible
- Because invalidation hurts and alienates
- Because feeling understood is one of our greatest needs
- Because it is the opposite of judgment.

Hearing

"I hear you"

Using our ears

Listening

"I'm listening"

Using our ears and mind

Understanding

"I understand"

Using our ears, mind & Heart

How do we validate?

Use a "reflecting statement" – simply reflect back the message or feeling

In response to:

"you never tell me anything that is going on"

"darn right, don't you think I should know"

"how do you think it makes me feel to be the last one to know"

"You don't really care about me"

"You should do it this way"



Say:

"I know you are concerned about what's happening"

"I know you care about me"

"I know you want to be kept informed, I don't want you to feel left out"

"I can understand that you might feel that way"

"I understand you think that is best, and this is what I'm comfortable with"

Remember: we can only change our own behaviour, yet by doing so we become more effective in influencing a change in other's behaviour!

"Seek first to understand, then to be understood"